Calling Agent

What it costs us, and what we should charge for it · 13 October 2026 · USD 1 = Rs 278

A one-minute conversation with our AI costs us about Rs 3.52.

The cheapest competitor in the world charges Rs 22.24 a minute. Most charge Rs 38.92. If we charge Rs 13.90 we are the cheapest on the market, and we still keep roughly three rupees in every four.

This document is for anyone who needs to talk about the money without needing to know how the software works. Nothing here is estimated or rounded up for comfort. Every figure comes either from a published price list or from our own bills, and every sum is done by the script that produced this page. The sister document, *calling-agent-pricing.pdf*, shows the same numbers with the workings and the sources.

The whole thing in five lines

- We sell an assistant that answers phone calls and WhatsApp messages for a business, in its own voice, around the clock.
- Every minute it talks, we pay Google about Rs 3.52. That is almost the entire cost of the product.
- On top of that, a normal phone call has a **second** bill from the phone company. WhatsApp calls do not. That single difference is the most important fact in this document.
- Competitors charge between four and ten times what the service costs them, because they can. We have the same room.
- So we price WhatsApp and SIM separately, we pass the phone company's charge straight through, and we never bury it inside a package.

What the customer is actually buying

A business gives us two things: a phone number or WhatsApp account, and a page of information about itself — its prices, its hours, its rules, whatever its customers ask about. From then on, when somebody calls or messages that business, our assistant answers instead of a person. It speaks, it listens, it answers from the information it was given, and it hangs up politely when the conversation is over.

It can work in four directions, and the direction matters to the price, so it is worth being clear about them.

The customer wants	In plain words	Who starts it
Calls answered	Their customers ring the business and our assistant picks up	The caller
Calls made	Our assistant rings a list of people on the business's behalf	Us
Messages answered	Somebody writes on WhatsApp and gets a real answer in seconds	The customer
Messages sent	The business announces something to a list of people	Us

Where our money actually goes

Three places, and they are very different sizes. It helps to picture the assistant as a very fast employee who is paid by the second, working on a phone line someone else owns.

We pay	For what	How it is charged	Roughly
Google	The thinking and the voice. This is the assistant itself — understanding what was said and saying something back.	By the second of conversation	Rs 3.52 a minute
The phone company	Carrying an ordinary phone call over the normal telephone network.	By the minute, and only for real phone calls	Varies hugely — see below
Meta (WhatsApp)	Letting us message and call through WhatsApp. Replies to people who wrote to us first are free.	Per message we start; calls in are free	Rs 0.00 to Rs 13.15
Servers	Keeping the website and the system switched on, whether anyone uses it or not.	A flat monthly fee	Rs 14,734 a month, total

Notice the shape of that list. Three of the four lines are small or fixed. The phone company is the only one that can get out of hand, and it only appears when we make an ordinary phone call.

The four ways a conversation can happen, cheapest first

This is the single most useful table in the document. Same assistant, same quality, same minute of talking — the only thing that changes is how the sound gets from the person to us.

How the conversation happens	What we pay Google	What we pay to carry it	Total, per minute
Someone **WhatsApp calls** the business	Rs 3.52	**free**	**Rs 3.52**
Someone **phones** the business normally	Rs 3.52	Rs 1.11	**Rs 4.63**
We **WhatsApp call** someone	Rs 3.52	Rs 3.17	**Rs 6.69**
We **phone** someone normally	Rs 3.52	Rs 50.04	**Rs 53.56**

Read the first row and the last row together.

An incoming WhatsApp call costs us Rs 3.52 a minute. Us ringing a mobile costs Rs 53.56 a minute — about 15 times as much, for exactly the same conversation. The difference is not our software. It is the phone company.

Everything in our pricing follows from this. We should sell WhatsApp hard, sell answering calls happily, and treat making ordinary phone calls as a pass-through where the customer pays the phone bill.

And a WhatsApp message?

Answering someone who messaged us first costs Rs 0.38 — thirty-eight paisa. A business could have a thousand messages answered for the price of a cup of tea, because Meta lets us reply free for 24 hours after someone writes to us, and the assistant's thinking on a short message is almost nothing.

Starting the conversation is where Meta charges. A useful notice — an order update, an appointment reminder — costs Rs 3.16. An advertisement costs Rs 13.53, roughly 4 times more. Advertising messages should never be included in a monthly package; they should be sold by the message.

Who brings the phone number and the WhatsApp account

Customers arrive in one of five situations, and they are not equally profitable. The question behind all of them is simple: when the phone company sends a bill, whose name is on it?

The situation	What they bring	Whose name is on the phone bill	What it means for us
A. They have everything	Their own WhatsApp business account and their own phone account	Theirs	**Best case.** We charge a flat fee plus a rate per minute and carry no risk at all.
B. Their WhatsApp, our phone line	Just the WhatsApp account	Ours, for calls	Fine, as long as we charge the phone cost through with a margin and never fix the price.
C. We provide everything	Nothing	Ours, for all of it	**Charge a setup fee.** Buying a number and getting approvals takes days of real work.
D. WhatsApp only, their account	The WhatsApp account	Nobody's — there is no phone bill	**Also excellent.** Pure software margin, nothing to pass through.
E. WhatsApp only, our account	Nothing	Nobody's, but we pay Meta	Good. Only the messages we start cost anything.

A and D are the two to chase. In both, we never see a phone bill, so there is no rate we have to guess at and nothing that can move against us. They are also the easiest to quote, because the price is just our software.

What everyone else charges

These are the companies a customer will find if they search instead of calling us. All figures converted to rupees a minute.

Company	Advertised	Realistically, all in	The catch
Vapi	Rs 13.90	Rs 22.24 to Rs 41.70	The advertised price is only their own fee. The AI and the phone call are billed separately on top.
Retell AI	Rs 15.29	Rs 29.19 to Rs 43.09	Same again — the headline covers their software, not the AI or the phone call.
Bland AI	Rs 38.92	Rs 38.92 to Rs 38.92	Genuinely all in, with no monthly fee, but nearly three times our price.
Synthflow	Rs 41.70	Rs 41.70 to Rs 66.72	The dearest of the four, and their cheap self-serve tiers appear to have been withdrawn.
Us, recommended	**Rs 13.90**	**Rs 13.90**	**No catch. That is the price, and it is all in.**

The gap between the first and second columns is how this industry works. The advertised number is a platform fee, and the AI and the phone call are billed on top, so the real bill lands two or three times higher than the headline. We can quote one honest number and still be the cheapest, which is a better sales story than a cheap headline with surprises behind it.

What we should charge

WhatsApp and SIM are priced separately because they cost us different amounts. Charging one price for both would either overcharge every WhatsApp customer or lose money on every phone customer.

What we sell	It costs us	We charge	We keep	Cheapest rival
A minute, WhatsApp call in	Rs 3.52	**Rs 13.90**	75%	Rs 22.24+
A minute, WhatsApp call out	Rs 6.69	**Rs 18.07**	63%	Rs 22.24+
A minute, phone call in	Rs 4.63	**Rs 16.68**	72%	Rs 22.24+
A minute, phone call out	Rs 3.52 + the phone bill	**the phone bill + Rs 13.90**	Rs 13.90	nobody competes here

The last row is the important one, and it is deliberately not a fixed price. We charge whatever the phone company charges us, plus our usual fee for the assistant. The customer sees exactly what the call cost. We never promise a price for something we do not control.

Messages

What we sell	It costs us	We charge	We keep
Answering someone who wrote to us	Rs 0.38	**Rs 1.11**	66%
A useful notice we send	Rs 3.16	**Rs 5.00**	37%
An advertisement we send	Rs 13.53	**Rs 18.07**	25%

Monthly packages

Most customers would rather pay one predictable figure than count minutes. These three bundles do that without giving away the margin. Anything used beyond the bundle is billed at the per-minute rates above.

Package	What they get	It costs us	We charge	We keep
Starter	300 minutes and 1,000 messages a month	Rs 4,378	**Rs 25,000**	82%
Growth	1,500 minutes and 5,000 messages a month	Rs 10,101	**Rs 95,000**	89%
Business	6,000 minutes and 20,000 messages a month	Rs 31,565	**Rs 330,000**	90%

Two rules for these packages. The monthly server cost is already shared across them, so the figures are real, not optimistic. And ordinary outbound phone minutes are never included — they are sold as an add-on at cost plus our fee, for the reason the red box on page 2 explains.

The one thing that could spoil this

Everything above holds as long as we are careful about one number: what the phone company charges us to ring a Pakistani mobile.

We do not know it yet. Infobip, the provider this system uses, does not publish its rates — you have to ask them. The only public figure we can point at is Twilio's, a competitor, at Rs 50.04 a minute. Infobip should be cheaper, possibly as low as Rs 1.71, but until somebody logs into the Infobip portal and reads the billing page, that is a hope rather than a fact.

> **Why it matters:** at Twilio's published rate, one outbound phone minute costs more than 14 minutes of WhatsApp conversation.
>
> If we ever sold outbound phone minutes at a flat Rs 13.90, we would lose money on every single one. That is precisely why the recommendation above passes the phone bill through instead of swallowing it.

What to do about it: get the real Pakistan rate from the Infobip portal under Billing, or from the account manager. It is one number, it takes one conversation, and it is the only genuinely unknown figure in this entire document.

Two changes worth more than any price rise

Before raising a single price, there are two things on our own side that cut the cost by more than any price change could add.

1. Use the cheaper brain for messages

Google sells several models. The one the system uses for written replies is the expensive one. The cheaper one is perfectly good for answering a WhatsApp question, and costs about 80% less — Rs 10.68 a message becomes Rs 2.17. Same answers, a fraction of the bill.

2. Keep the information sheet short

Here is something genuinely surprising, and it is worth explaining because it is the easiest money in the business. Every single time the assistant speaks or writes, it re-reads the *entire* information sheet the business gave us. Not once a day — every time.

So the length of that sheet is a permanent, repeating cost. One of our test customers has a long one and it costs Rs 4.96 per call just to read. Another has a tight one: Rs 0.79. Halving a sheet halves that line forever, on every call, for as long as the customer stays.

Do both and a message falls from Rs 10.68 to Rs 0.38 — about 28 times cheaper. No price change available to us moves the business that much.

Words you will hear in meetings

The word	What it actually means
Inbound	They call us. Cheap, and the direction to prefer.
Outbound	We call them. Carries a phone bill.
SIM call	An ordinary telephone call over the normal phone network, the kind anyone can receive.
WhatsApp call	A call made inside the WhatsApp app over the internet. No phone company involved, so far cheaper.
Knowledge base	The sheet of information the business gives us about itself, which the assistant answers from.
Template	A message we are allowed to send first, which Meta must approve in advance. Either a useful notice or an advertisement, and they are priced very differently.
The 24-hour window	After someone messages the business, we may reply free for a day. This is why answering is nearly free and starting a conversation is not.
Pass-through	A cost we hand to the customer at exactly what we paid, rather than guessing at it and fixing a price.
Margin	The share of the price we keep after the costs of delivering it.

Produced by docs/build_plain_report.py, which takes its figures directly from docs/build_pricing_report.py — the same source as the detailed pricing document, so the two cannot disagree. For the workings, the sources and the figures that are still unproven, see calling-agent-pricing.pdf.